the only pro-establishment ethnic political party nationwide that managed to do so, which comes as a big surprise and warrants closer scrutiny.[22]

It is important to point out that the 2015 win came on the back of three negative developments as far as the PNO is concerned. First, the PNO had two challengers in the shape of the NLD and UPNO. Second, villagers were more aware of their rights and the purpose of the election due to better voter education organized by CSOs. Third, voting irregularities were at a minimum under the watchful eyes of international observers. How did the PNO manage the win amid the challenging circumstances? Finding the answer will reveal how power is asserted at the micro level in the Pa-O SAZ.

The conventional administrative structure that links village with township is the village tract system. Villages are grouped into village tracts. The number of villages in a tract depends on the size of the villages, and sometimes can be more than twenty. Each village has a headman, and each village tract also has a leader, who serves to co-ordinate the village headmen and acts as the main conduit between the villages and township. The township administrator appoints the village tract leader, who is not necessarily a village headman within the tract.

The authority of village headmen has been culturally embedded in Burma's rural society (Hackett 1953; Leach 1954, pp. 159–71), therefore, they naturally become the targets for political control by outside forces. But instead of forming a patron-client relationship with the villagers, the PNO controls them in two ways. First, it holds the power to appoint the village tract leader, who uses his authority to command villagers. Second, the PNO instils fear into villagers with the threat of violence, because it has enjoyed a monopoly on use of force in Special Region 6 (and subsequently the Pa-O SAZ) since signing its ceasefire agreement.

Referring to the 2010 election, the chairman of UPNO explained the technique the PNO uses to control votes:

> Each village has a village head, and four to six villages combine to have one representative, referred to as the 'executive head'.[23] The PNO appoint the executive head. During the 2010 election, the SNDP wanted to talk to the villagers. However, the PNO told the villagers not to go because it would not be safe. Instead, they asked the villagers to send the executive village heads to attend. In the election, the executive village heads all voted for the PNO, and the villagers followed.[24]